



Assessment Policy

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Version Control			
Previous Version	New Version	Date	Update/Notes
V1.4 (21-06-24)	V2	15-04-25	- Added version control table and some formatting. - Updated the external reference point to include OfS condition - B4 and replaced UK Quality Code March 2018 with UK Quality Code June 2024 Principle 11. - Updated protocol on giving group formative assessments for fairness.
V2 (15-04-25)	V3	26/08/25	Rewrite many sections for clarity of meaning and to include ATHE as well Pearson HND.
V3 (26/08/25)	V4	14-05-26	Added information on Special Considerations under the section on Mitigating Circumstances to align with the update Special Considerations and Reasonable Adjustments Policy and added a Mitigating Circumstances Form in Appendix A
V4 (14-05-26)	V5.2	25-08-26	Rewrote the introduction, purpose and scope and aims and objectives with clear definitions of validity, reliability, consistency and accuracy of assessments. Added a note on English language examinations. An updated section on when formative feedback may be provided equitably to individual students. Assessment regulations, assessment board and marking process sections have all been updated.

Contents

1. Introduction.....	4
2. Purpose and Scope	4
3. Aims and Objectives.....	5
4. Definitions.....	6
4.1. Summative Assessment	6
4.2. Formative Assessment.....	6
5. Assessment Regulations	7
5.1. Summative Submission Deadline.....	7
5.2. Late Summative Submissions	7
5.3. Resubmission Deadline	7
5.4. Retakes.....	8
5.5. Mitigating Circumstances	8
5.6. Mitigating Circumstances Panel (MCP)	9
5.7. Submission Feedback.....	9
5.8. Internal Verification	9
5.9. Sampling Method.....	10
5.10. External Examination	10
6. Assessment Board	11
6.1. Overview	11
6.2. Timings and Frequency of Assessment Board Meetings.....	11
6.3. Terms of Reference	12
6.4. Results.....	12
6.5. Appeals and Complaints.....	12
7. The process of marking and giving feedback.....	13
7.1. Resubmissions	13
7.2. Retakes.....	13
7.3. Failure to Pass	13
7.4. Grades for Pearson BTEC HND and for ATHE Extended Diploma Level 4/5	14
7.5. Compensatory Credit for HND	14
7.6. Calculating Overall Grade for HND.....	14
7.7. Publishing Grades.....	15
Appendix 1 - Mitigating Circumstances Form.....	16
Appendix 2 - TEC HND/ATHE L4 Assessment Plan Template (HND/ATHE L4/L5).....	18

1. Introduction

Trent Education Centre (TEC) is committed to ensuring its higher education assessments are conducted according to fair, transparent and clearly explained regulations and procedures which are known and understood by all students and academic staff. It is essential that all assessments decisions are valid, reliable, consistent and accurate according to recognised standards.

This policy provides all the information that is needed for students and academic staff to participate in assessments effectively. It is specifically aligned with the regulations of TEC's ATHE L4/L5 Extended Diploma in Business and Management and Pearson BTEC Higher National Diploma in Business.

Students enrolled on courses delivered by TEC in partnership with other providers or awarding bodies should refer to the assessment regulations of the relevant partner unless otherwise notified. Information on which regulations and policies apply is provided in the relevant Course Handbook on the TEC website and explained during enrolment and induction. A link to this policy is also available on TEC's Virtual Learning Environment (VLE) where relevant.

2. Purpose and Scope

This policy provides comprehensive information on assessment arrangements for higher education courses delivered by TEC. Currently TEC offers the ATHE Extended Diploma in Business Management (Level 4/5) and the Pearson BTEC Higher National Diploma (HND) in Business (Level 4/5). This policy has been written to ensure compliance with the assessment regulations and procedures required by these awarding organisations across all TEC Study Centres.

If any additional qualifications require alternative assessment regulations, this policy will be updated accordingly. Students and staff may refer directly to ATHE and Pearson assessment regulations where appropriate. TEC will ensure that all assessments are conducted in line with the requirements of the relevant awarding organisation.

3. Aims and Objectives

This policy ensures that assessments give students the opportunity to demonstrate valid learning and achievement relevant to their academic and employability needs and the qualification they are studying for. It aims to:

- Enable students to achieve threshold levels and beyond threshold levels, with opportunities for all students to develop, improve and achieve to the highest possible standards.
- Provide clear information to students and tutors/assessors on how assessments are designed, graded and how assessors mark and give targeted, developmental feedback to students on their assignment submissions.
- Ensure assessments are compliant with relevant regulations of awarding bodies and organisations.

The objectives of this policy are to ensure that:

- Assessments are **valid**; they test the knowledge, skills and behaviours intended by the learning outcomes for the award
- Assessments are **accurate**; grades and feedback given by the assessor correctly reflects the standard of work against published assessment criteria and marking rubric
- Assessments are **reliable**; over time assessors apply the same criteria and give the same grade for the same standard of work
- Assessments are **consistent**; assessment decisions are equivalent across all assessors, modules/units and cohorts
- Assessment criteria are based on clearly defined learning outcomes.
- Assessments are equitable, with reasonable adjustments made for disabled students or those with specific learning needs to ensure fairness.
- Assessments are designed to meet academic standards and support the employability needs of students.
- Students are provided with all necessary information and support to complete their assessments effectively.
- A holistic approach is used to evaluate students' overall performance and understanding
- Students are given clear, constructive, targeted and developmental feedback that informs improvement
- Feedback is provided in a timely manner (within three weeks of submission)
- Assessments are sampled and internally verified/moderated in accordance with a robust internal verification policy.
- Assessment decisions are submitted to the TEC Assessment Board for ratification twice every year, including within six months of receiving External Examination reports.

4. Definitions

An assessment is a student's completion of a specific task or activity outlined in an assignment brief or examination, which is then graded by an assessor to determine the student's proficiency in relation to the requirements of the qualification.

Assessments may be formative (developmental, not graded) or summative (graded, contributing to the final outcome). Assessments may be submitted in a variety of formats, including written work, practical tasks, oral presentations, digital submissions, posters, or observed interactions.

TEC may also conduct invigilated examinations for specific programmes. Currently only some of TEC's English language courses have examinations rather than assessments. Further details are provided in the TEC Examinations Policy.

4.1. Summative Assessment

A summative assessment is the final piece of assessed work a student must complete for a particular unit or module. Summative assessments normally take the form of coursework submitted by a published deadline, although some units or modules may also require an invigilated examination.

Summative assessments are usually scheduled shortly after teaching for the unit or module has been completed. Submission deadlines are set at the start of the academic semester or term and are detailed in the assignment brief, which outlines the required tasks, expectations and submission instructions.

4.2. Formative Assessment

Formative assessment is used by tutors to monitor students' understanding and progress during the delivery of a unit or module. It provides ongoing feedback and enables tutors to adjust teaching approaches to better support learning. Formative assessment may take many forms, including quizzes, short written tasks, discussions, observations, exit tickets, or sample drafts.

Formative feedback does not contribute to the student's final grade for the unit or module. Its purpose is to help students understand how they can improve their performance in preparation for the summative assessment.

To ensure fairness, tutors normally provide group feedback on formative tasks so that no individual student receives an unfair advantage. Individual formative feedback will only be provided when:

- It is offered equally to all students in the cohort even if some students choose not to use the opportunity.
- A student requires reasonable adjustments or special consideration due to a disclosed learning need or disability.

5. Assessment Regulations

The following assessment regulations comply with the requirements set by ATHE and Pearson for the higher education courses currently offered by TEC.

5.1. Summative Submission Deadline

Students are required to submit assignments and/or complete exams by published deadlines, which are clearly stated in the assignment briefs for each module or unit. These deadlines are also communicated during induction and are available on the TEC Virtual Learning Environment (VLE), where students submit their work.

All deadlines are fixed and students are expected to submit on time. Missing the submission and resubmission deadlines will result in the grade being capped at a Pass unless there are mitigating circumstance. Students who are unable to submit by the deadline due to valid reasons may apply for **mitigating circumstances** as outlined below.

In exceptional cases, deadlines may be adjusted if events outside TEC's control affect a significant number of students. Any adjustments will always provide students with more time, not less, and will be communicated in advance.

5.2. Late Summative Submissions

If a student fails to submit by the published summative deadline, the submission will be considered late. Students may still submit their assignment by the resubmission deadline (see below), but their mark will be capped at a Pass.

5.3. Resubmission Deadline

Students who submit their work by the summative deadline will receive a grade and developmental feedback within three weeks. Students who do not achieve a Pass will be given one resubmission opportunity, normally within two weeks of receiving feedback, to address the feedback and resubmit their assignment. All resubmissions will be capped at a Pass.

Feedback on formative assessments is developmental and identifies areas for improvement without providing specific coaching on what the student needs to submit for the summative assignment.

5.4. Retakes

There is only one resubmission opportunity and the grade is capped at a Pass. Students who achieve a Pass or higher on their first submission cannot resubmit a second time to improve their grade. Students who fail to submit by the resubmission deadline, or who resubmit but do not achieve a Pass, must retake the unit or module.

Students who retake a unit or module will be given a new summative deadline and resubmission deadline. **Retake grades are capped at a Pass.** Retakes may incur additional fees, as outlined in TEC's Terms and Conditions and Tuition Fees, Refunds and Compensation Policy.

It is in the student's best interest to submit and pass each unit or module by the published summative or resubmission deadline to avoid the need for a retake.

5.5. Mitigating Circumstances

If students are unable to meet a submission deadline, they should contact their Programme Leader as soon as possible to explain the situation. Where a student has valid reasons for missing a deadline, they must complete the **Mitigating Circumstances Form** in Appendix A and submit it by email to mitcircs@trenteducation.ac.uk.

Students may also submit a **Mitigating Circumstances Form** after an assessment if they believe they should be considered under TEC's Special Considerations and Reasonable Adjustments Policy. Special Considerations are defined by the Joint Council for Qualifications (JCQ) as:

A post-assessment adjustment to a candidate's mark or grade to reflect temporary illness, injury or other indisposition at the time of the assessment.

When submitting a Mitigating Circumstances Form, students must provide a valid explanation for why they were unable to submit their work on time, or why they wish to be considered for a post-assessment Special Consideration. Valid reasons may include:

1. Physical or mental health issues

Students may be required to provide medical documentation. TEC may also refer students to counselling or well-being support.

2. Bereavement

TEC will normally approve mitigating circumstances in cases of bereavement and will offer appropriate support.

3. Disability or learning difficulty

Students with disclosed disabilities or learning needs may receive reasonable adjustments or special considerations as required.

4. Technical difficulties

Where technical issues prevented submission, TEC may approve mitigating circumstances and assist the student in resolving the problem.

5. Impact of crime

If a student has been affected by a crime, mitigating circumstances may be granted and additional support offered to the student.

6. Unexpected caring responsibilities

Students who unexpectedly become responsible for caring for a relative may receive flexibility and support.

The following reasons are not considered valid grounds for mitigating circumstances and will not be accepted:

- Excessive workload or conflicting commitments such as paid employment.
- Not understanding the assignment requirements, including missing classes or support sessions.
- Travelling for personal or career-related reasons.
- Wanting additional time to improve the quality of the submission.

5.6. Mitigating Circumstances Panel (MCP)

The Programme Leader chairs the Mitigating Circumstances Panel (MCP), which considers requests for extensions to submission deadlines due to mitigating circumstances. The MCP consists of the following members:

- Programme Leader (Chair)
- Assessors
- Student Support Staff

Normally, the Programme Leader or their nominee may make decisions on individual requests for extensions. The MCP will only convene when there is a high volume of mitigating circumstances requests or when cases require collective consideration to ensure consistency and fairness.

5.7. Submission Feedback

Students should receive written feedback on their summative assessments no later than three weeks after their submission. If students submit their assignments on extended deadlines due to mitigating circumstances, feedback deadlines will be subject to the availability of assessors. Group feedback will be given for formative assessments apart from cases where individual formative feedback may be given as explained in the section on Formative Assessments above. Students will receive individual, personalised and detailed feedback for summative assessments.

5.8. Internal Verification

Internal verification is the term used by Pearson awarding organisation for the following processes:

- Giving feedback on written assignment briefs and approving or verifying the assignment briefs before they are handed to students.
- Giving feedback to assessors on the feedback they have provided to students and verification of the grades provided before they are published for students and made available to external examiners.

The ATHE awarding organisation refers to the Internal Verifier (IV) as the Internal Quality Assurer (IQA).

An IV or IQA is assigned to each assessor by the Lead IV, who is the Programme Lead or their nominee. The IV/IQA and Lead IV cannot also be the Assessor for the unit or module being verified. The IV or IQA for each unit or module selects a sample of assessments based upon the sampling method set out in the Internal Verification Policy and explained below. The IV or IQA confirms or disputes the accuracy of the grade and provides feedback to the assessor.

5.9. Sampling Method

Every unit/module assessed must be sampled for internal verification purposes. This applies to both summative submissions and resubmissions. Sampling is based upon the square root of the number of assessments for each unit/module. For example, if there are 36 assessments, the IV or IQA will sample six of them. If there are 50, they will sample seven. When a unit/module is assessed by multiple assessors, the number of submissions internally verified should be evenly distributed among them. The IV or IQA will sample assessments across the full range of grades given. For ATHE and HND courses, this would mean sampling work that has failed or referred and attained a pass, merit and distinction.

Sampling is also risk-based. If there are known issues with a unit/module, a group of students or an assessor, the IV or IQA may choose to sample more than the usual amount up to the entire batch of assessments if required.

If the IV or IQA has a different opinion to the assessor about a grade provided for an assessment, the assessor can either:

- Adjust the grade and feedback accordingly before sharing it with the student, or
- Disagree with the IV or IQA and ask for a second opinion from the Lead IV or IQA.

If there is a disagreement, the Lead IV will take account of the views of both the Assessor and the IV before reaching their decision. Once the grade has been decided by the Lead IV, it will be passed to students.

If there have been changes to grades from the assessor to the IV, the assessor may need to return to all the assessment decisions for the same unit or module and reassess them to make sure they follow the same agreed standard of assessment. See the TEC **Internal Verification Policy** for more information.

5.10. External Examination

TEC ensures that it complies fully with the external examination process conducted by the Pearson External Examiner (EE) and the external quality assurance (EQA) processes conducted by the ATHE External Quality Assurer (EQA). Through external examination or external quality assurance, TEC ensures that its assessments, IV or IQA processes meet approved standards. The awarding organisations usually hold external examinations or external quality assurance visits once per annum and provide the academic team with a report that may include essential actions or recommendations for improvements. The EE and EQA reports are submitted to the relevant Course Committee for review and action planning. They are then submitted to the Academic Board for approval. The feedback from these reports is used to inform the Annual Academic Monitoring Review (AAMR) submitted by the Academic Board to the Board of Governors.

6. Assessment Board

6.1. Overview

The following assessment regulations comply with the requirements set by ATHE and Pearson for the higher education courses currently offered by TEC. For programmes delivered by TEC in partnership with another provider at any time in the future, the partner's assessment regulations will apply unless staff and students are otherwise notified.

The Assessment Board has delegated powers from the Academic Board to make decisions regarding student results, continuation, completion and awards. The Assessment Board also ratifies resubmissions, retakes, cases of mitigating circumstances and academic misconduct submitted to it by the Academic Misconduct Board. The Academic Board has overall oversight of the standards and quality of all academic programmes at TEC. The Assessment Board makes recommendations for the following standing items on its agenda:

- The authorised grade for every unit or module of study achieved by each student
- Mitigating circumstances outcomes submitted by the Programme Leader
- Cases of academic misconduct including plagiarism or other forms of cheating
- Continuation of students to the next level or year of study e.g. from HNC to HND
- Conferment of awards to students
- Ratification of Referrals, deferrals or resubmissions
- Monitoring of standardisation meetings and internal verification and internal quality assurance processes and decisions to ensure that academic standards and quality are maintained

6.2. Timings and Frequency of Assessment Board Meetings

The TEC HND/ATHE L4 & 5 **Assessment Plan Template in Appendix 2** provides an example of the timings and frequency of Assessment Boards if TEC runs two semesters per year for its L4 & L5 ATHE and HND courses. The template is for illustrative purposes only and the Head of Higher Education may approve the adoption of a different assessment plan after consultation with the Programme Leader. The academic calendar and assessment plan will be shared with students before they enrol and during their induction.

In the Assessment Plan in Appendix 2, the Assessment Board meets twice a year. This includes an **Intermediate Assessment Board** after the end of the first Semester in week 19 (excluding holidays) and an **End of Session Assessment Board** after the end of the second Semester in week 22. The End of Session Assessment Board is held after the External Examiner (EE) or External Quality Assurer (EQA) visit which is planned for week 20 in the second semester, two weeks before the Assessment Board, which allows time to receive the EE or EQA report.

The Programme Leader has delegated powers from the Assessment Board to oversee the provision of feedback and provisional grades to students following internal verification or internal quality assurance of work submitted for units in the middle of the Semester (usually week 8). Typically, for a 16-week Semester, students will receive feedback and provisional grades in week 11 for units that have been submitted in week 8. These provisional grades are authorised (ratified) retrospectively by the Assessment Board in week 19, along with grades for the units that are submitted in week 16. The Programme Leader also has delegated powers from the Assessment Board to authorise feedback and grades for resubmissions that are provided after the Assessment Board (typically, week 21). There may also be Reassessment Board meetings convened for students retaking a unit.

6.3. Terms of Reference

Like all other TEC Boards and Committees, the Assessment Board has Terms of Reference that include the following information:

- Purpose of the Assessment Board
- Whom it reports to
- Whom it receives reports from
- Membership
- Quorum
- Frequency

Refer to the Terms of Reference or the Governance and Academic Management Framework (GAMF) which contains all the Terms of Reference for all TEC boards and committees.

6.4. Results

Students receive provisional feedback and grades through feedback provided by their Tutor/Assessor after passing internal verification (IV) or internal quality assurance (IQA) and this is authorised by the Programme Leader until it may be ratified at the next meeting of the Assessment Board. Students are informed that all grades are provisional and require ratification by the EE or EQA and the TEC End of Session Assessment Board. All provisional grades may be subject to amendments by the EE, EQA and End of Session Assessment Board. Students are informed when they receive their grades and feedback if their grades are provisional or final. They are reminded that provisional grades cannot be used for continuation or award decisions until ratified.

6.5. Appeals and Complaints

Student will have an opportunity to lodge an appeal or complaint after receiving their results. Refer to the Student Complaints and Appeals Policy and Academic Appeals Policy on the TEC website for more information on lodging a complaint or academic appeal. Students must submit appeals within the time specified in the Academic Appeals Policy. If TEC is delivering a programme in partnership with another provider, the partners Academic Appeals Policy will apply unless staff and students are otherwise notified.

7. The process of marking and giving feedback

Submission of assignments

Summative submissions are submitted by the student by the deadline.

The Tutor/Assessor provides feedback and assigns a grade to the student within two weeks, following the assessment criteria outlined in the Assignment Brief and Programme Specification.

Within three weeks

All submissions are marked by an assessor and sampled by the internal verifier to ensure validity, accuracy, reliability and consistency of all assessment decisions as well as fairness in terms of developmental feedback. Students receive their feedback and grade and can only appeal against them if they believe there was a procedural error, failure to make reasonable adjustments, or bias. Refer to the Academic Appeals Policy for further information.

7.1. Resubmissions

Students who do not submit their work by the summative deadline or who submit by the deadline but do not Pass, will be allowed one resubmission opportunity. Normally the resubmission deadline is two weeks after feedback is given on the summative deadline. Students who pass on the summative deadline cannot resubmit as the grade on resubmissions are capped at a Pass unless the student has mitigating circumstances (See 5.6 above).

7.2. Retakes

Students failing their resubmission will be required to retake the unit and complete a new assignment or exam at a different deadline. Retakes will be capped at a Pass grade. Additional class attendance and scheduling may be necessary for retaking the unit, potentially resulting in extra tuition costs and extended course completion timelines. It is advisable for students to pass on their submission, or resubmission attempts to avoid these additional steps.

7.3. Failure to Pass

Students who do not pass the required number of units may not be able to continue to the next academic level. This means that an ATHE Level 4 student or HND Level 4 student, for instance, will not be able to achieve the full Level 4 award and continue to the next level. However, they will be able to continue studying and attain unit certificates. Students taking the Pearson HND course who are able to submit work for 8 units at Level 4 and pass six of them by the end of year one, will be able to continue to year two. However, they will need to pass at least one more Level 4 unit alongside the Level 5 units in order to pass the full HND award in the second year. All assessment decisions and decisions about continuation to the next level will be made by the TEC Assessment Board in line with the awarding organisation's regulations.

7.4. Grades for Pearson BTEC HND and for ATHE Extended Diploma Level 4/5

In ATHE Diplomas and Pearson BTEC HND students may receive four possible results:

REFERRED – Not passed

PASSED

MERIT

DISTINCTION

Students who are referred will have an opportunity to resubmit on the resubmission deadline, but their grade will be capped at a Pass unless they have mitigating circumstances. If they fail again, they may also have a final opportunity to retake the unit or module and pass.

7.5. Compensatory Credit for HND

Students pursuing Pearson BTEC HNDs may receive compensatory credit. After completing the HNC Level 4, they are eligible for compensatory credit for one 15-credit unit in their first year, and after completing the HND Level 5, they may receive another 15-credit unit of compensatory credit in their second year. This means students can still pass their HNC in the first year and their HND in the second year even if they fail one 15-credit unit at each respective level. However, passing the HNC or HND is not possible if more than one 15-credit unit is failed at either level. For guidance on achieving an overall Merit or Distinction, students should consult the Pearson BTEC Assessment Guidelines.

7.6. Calculating Overall Grade for HND

The following table illustrates how to calculate the overall grade for Pearson HNDs.

Grade	Points per Credit	Point Boundaries
Pass	4	420 - 599
Merit	6	600 - 839
Distinction	8	840 +

Credits earned in this points-based system are multiplied by a specific factor depending on the level of achievement. A Pass results in the unit's credits being multiplied by 4. If a Merit is achieved, the credits are multiplied by 6, and for a Distinction, they are multiplied by 8. Each Pass, Merit, or Distinction for a unit contributes to the total credit count through this weighted calculation.

The first year of study involves completing 8 HNC L4 units, each valued at 15 credits, while the second year includes 6 HND L5 units, also valued at 15 credits each, and one HND L5 unit for the Research Project which is worth 30 credits.

For example, passing a 15-credit unit would result in earning 60 points (4 x 15), achieving a Merit would result in 90 points (6 x 15), and achieving a Distinction would result in 120 points (8 x 15). At the end of the first year, the total points earned from all HNC units are added together to determine a final grade based on the total points accumulated.

7.7. Publishing Grades

All the grades that students receive from TEC assessors and internal verifiers or internal quality assurers are subject to change by the EE or EQA of the awarding organisation. The grades published by TEC are, therefore, provisional until they have been approved by EE or EQA and ratified at the TEC End of Session Assessment Board. This board will typically meet around six weeks after the second semester or third term has ended and soon after the final visit by the EE or EQA.

Appendix 1 - Mitigating Circumstances Form

This Mitigating Circumstances Form is for students requesting deadline extensions (pre-assessment) or Special Considerations (post-assessment). Students requesting mitigating circumstances should complete this form and send it by email to mitcircs@trenteducation.ac.uk. Alternatively, you can find a link to this form on the TEC website.

Student Details

Student's Full Name	
Student ID	
Programme	
Assessment of Exam Deadline	
Tutor/Assessor	

Request

Deadline Extension (Before the Deadline)	YES ☐ NO ☐
Special Consideration (After the Deadline)	YES ☐ NO ☐

What are you Mitigating Circumstances e.g. illness, injury or other? Explain what has happened and how it has affected your ability to submit your work or sit an exam, or how your performance has been affected post-assessment.	
Have you attached evidence to support your request?	YES ☐ NO ☐
Describe the evidence you have for your reasons given.	
Are you requesting an extension?	YES ☐ NO ☐
If YES, give the date you will be able to submit your work (the Programme Leader may not agree to your selected date of submission)	
Are you requesting special considerations?	YES ☐ NO ☐

Student Declaration

I confirm that the information provided in this form is accurate and truthful. I understand that providing false information may result in disciplinary action.

Signature	
Date	

TEC Staff Use Only

Programme Leader or nominated person	
Date the request is received	
The request is approved	YES ☐ NO ☐
The new extended deadline date	
Staff signature	
Date signed	

Appendix 2 - TEC HND/ATHE L4 Assessment Plan Template (HND/ATHE L4/L5)

Semester One

Units	Assessment Submission Date	IV of Assessment Date	Provisional Feedback Date	Planned Resubmission Date*	Resubmission Feedback Date	Assessment Submission Date	IV of Assessment Date	Intermediate Assessment Board (Semester 1)	Feedback Date	Planned Resubmission Date*	Resubmission Feedback Date
1st	Week 8	Week 10	Week 11	Week 13	Week 15			Week 19			
2nd	Week 8	Week 10	Week 11	Week 13	Week 15						
3rd						Week 16	Week 18		Week 19	Week 21	Week 23*
4th						Week 16	Week 18		Week 19	Week 21	Week 23*

Semester Two (HND/ATHE L4/L5)

Units	Assessment Submission Date	IV of Assessment Date	Provisional Feedback Date	Planned Resubmission Date*	Resubmission Feedback Date	Assessment Submission Date	IV of Assessment Date	Feedback Date	External Examine Visit	End of Session Assessment Board (Semester 2)	Planned Resubmission Date*	Resubmission Feedback Date
5th	Week 8	Week 10	Week 11	Week 13	Week 15				Week 20	Week 22		
6th	Week 8	Week 10	Week 11	Week 13	Week 15							
7th						Week 16	Week 18	Week 20			Week 22	Week 23*
8th						Week 16	Week 18	Week 20			Week 22	Week 23*

* Week numbers do not account for holidays